

Barriers to International Student Mobility

Survey Analysis – Four-Group Approach



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15 June 2026



The Survey

Who Are the Four Groups?

Measuring Overall Constraint

What Predicts Group Membership?

Conclusions



Sample

- **1230** total respondents
- **808** usable ($\geq 70\%$ of key variables)
- Median completion rate: **68%**

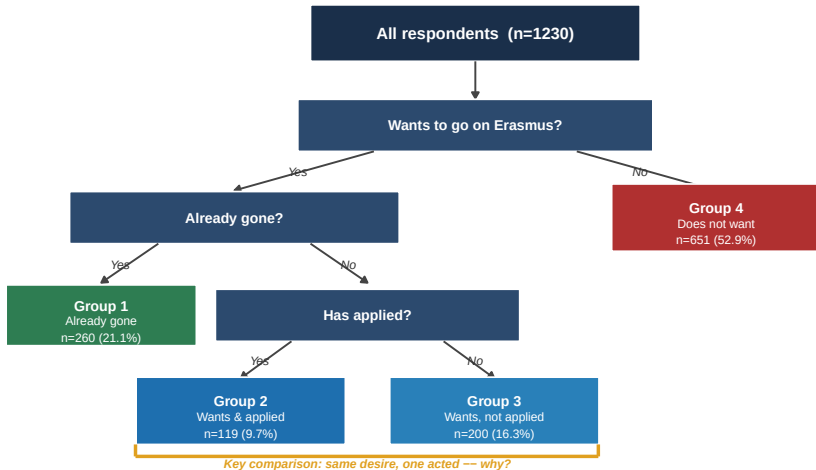
Four Groups

1. Already gone on Erasmus
2. Wants to go & has applied
3. Wants to go, has not applied
4. Does not want to go

Variables

- 16 barriers (Likert 1–5)
- 11 reasons for going
- 27 psychological profile items
- Socio-demographic variables
- **New:** Parental Erasmus (Q13), Certified English (Q24)

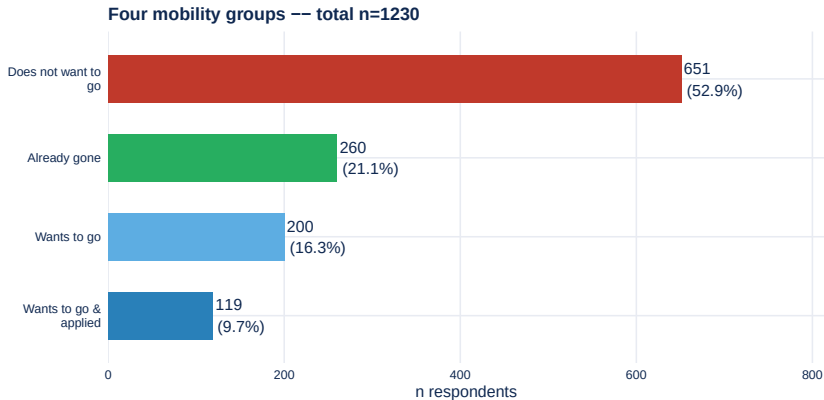
How Are the Four Groups Defined?



Decision tree: each student is assigned to exactly one group based on three binary questions. Groups 2 and 3 share the same desire for mobility – the key analytical question is what differentiates them.

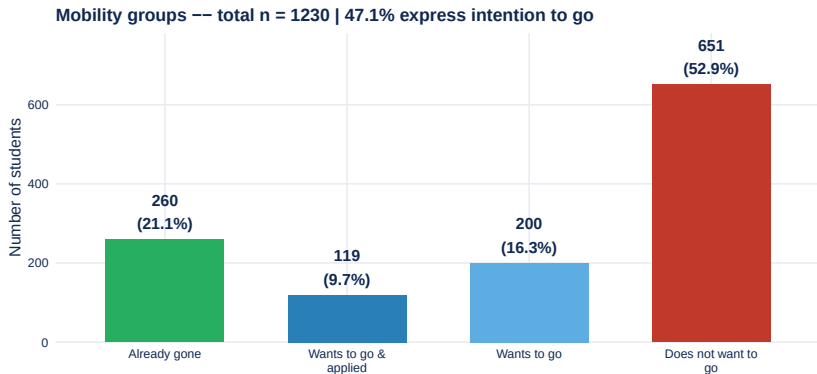


The Four Mobility Groups



Reading: each bar = number of students. Focus on Groups 2–3 (both want to go): the gap reveals how many are blocked at the application stage.

Departure Rates and Conversion Funnel



47.1% of respondents express some intention to go abroad. Among those who want to go, the conversion to application is the key lever studied.



Two Central Questions

- **Who** are the four groups?
(socio-demo, academic, financial, psychological)
- **What** differentiates students who applied from those who want to go but haven't?

Three Mechanisms

1. **Structural:** finances, grades, parental capital
2. **Psychological:** international profile, openness
3. **Informational:** lack of knowledge about procedures

Key Comparison

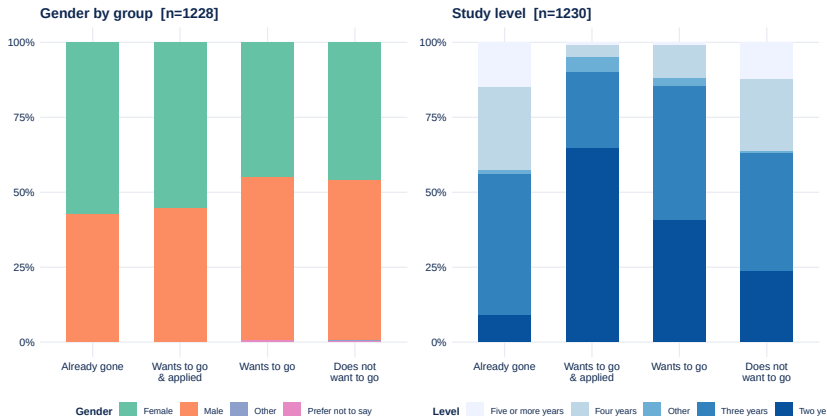
Groups 2 vs 3: same desire, but only one has taken action.

What makes the difference?

Methods

- Descriptive by group
- MCA + composite barrier score
- OLS on score
- Logistic regressions

Socio-Demographic Profile by Group



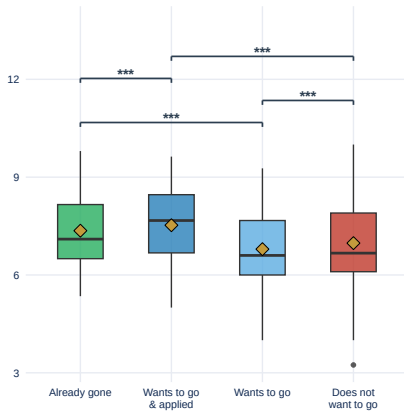
Reading: stacked bars show group composition. Look for visible differences in gender or study-level distribution – these signal structural selection into mobility.



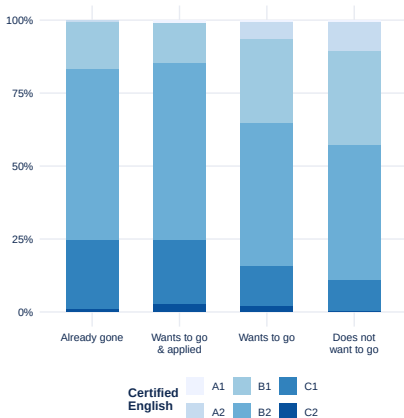
Academic and Language Profile by Group

Academic grade (norm. 0–10) [n=1221]

Diamond=mean — * p<0.05 ** p<0.01 *** p<0.001 (pairwise Wilcoxon)

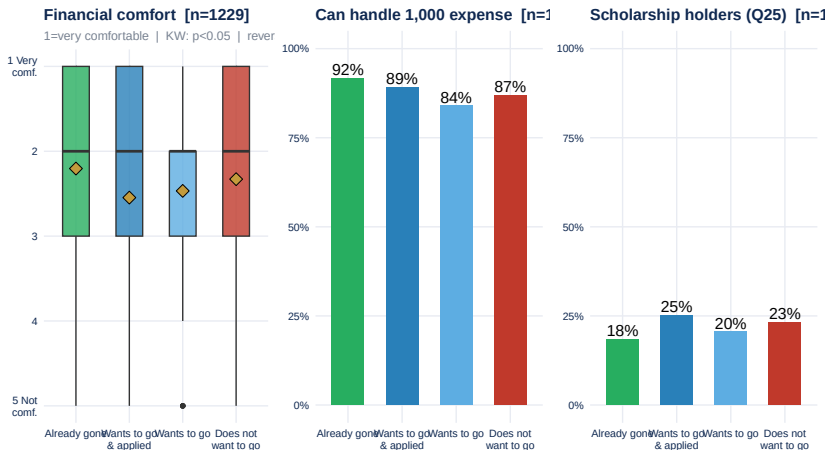


Certified English (Q24) [n=1025]



Reading: box = middle 50% of values, diamond = mean. A higher mean grade in Group 1 (already gone) would suggest academic selection into Erasmus participation.

Financial Profile by Group

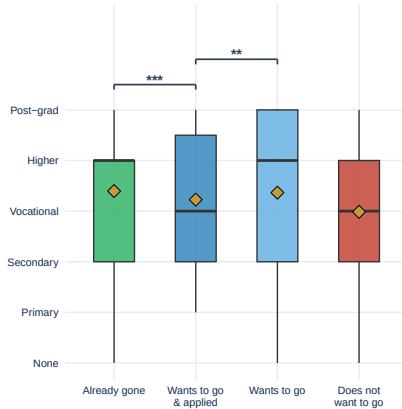


Left: financial comfort scale reversed (1=very comfortable). Kruskal-Wallis global test reported in subtitle. Significant pairs (Bonferroni): Already gone vs Wants to go *. Middle: share able to absorb a 1,000 unexpected expense. Right panel: share of scholarship holders (Q25) by group – higher scholarship rates in constrained groups would confirm structural financial barriers

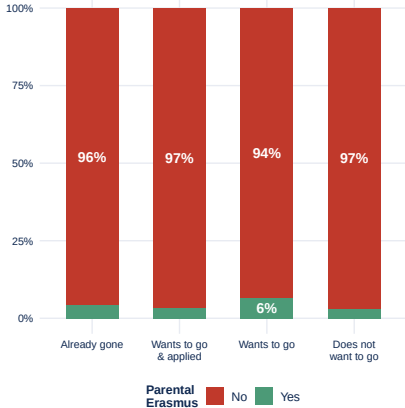
Parental Capital by Group

Parents' education level

* $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$ *** $p < 0.001$ (pairwise Wilcoxon, Bonferroni)



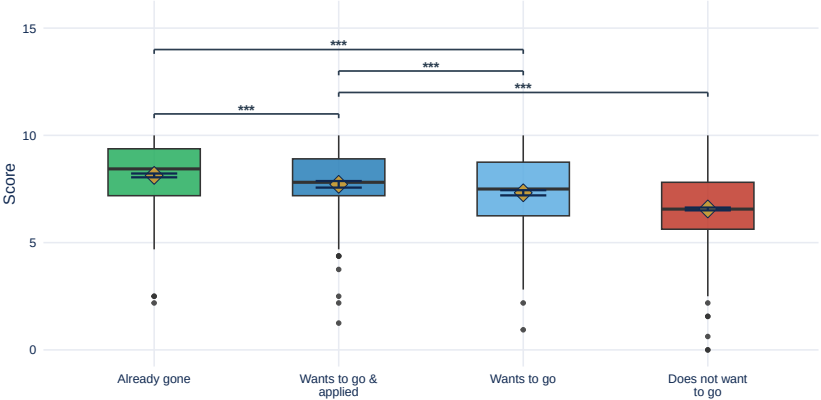
Parental Erasmus participation (Q13)



Reading: left = parents' education level (higher = more cultural capital). Right = parental Erasmus experience provides direct knowledge of the programme and process.

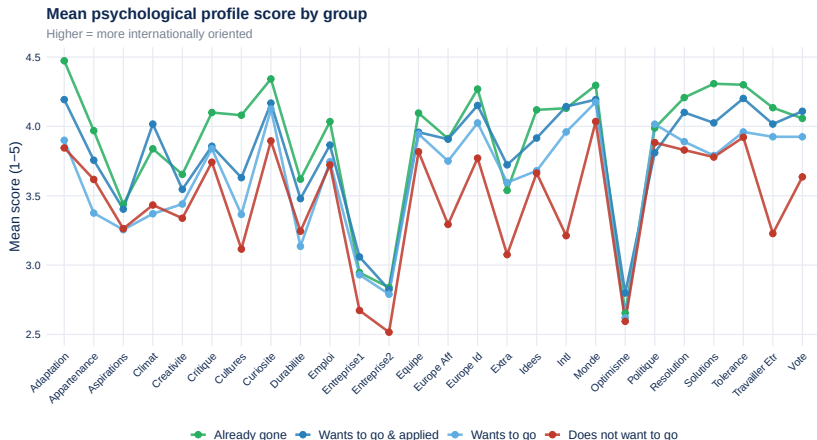
International profile score (0–10) by group

Diamond = mean $\pm$ SE | KW: $p < 0.001$ | * $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$ *** $p < 0.001$ (Wilcoxon, Bonferroni)



Kruskal-Wallis across 4 groups: $p < 0.001$. Pairwise brackets show Bonferroni-corrected Wilcoxon tests (significant pairs only). Higher score = more open to international mobility.

Psychological Profile: Group Differences



Reading: each line traces mean scores across 27 psychological dimensions. Groups 1-2 scoring higher on openness/international dimensions than Group 4 would confirm the psychological mechanism.

Are Group Differences Statistically Significant?

Table 1: Group differences: statistical tests

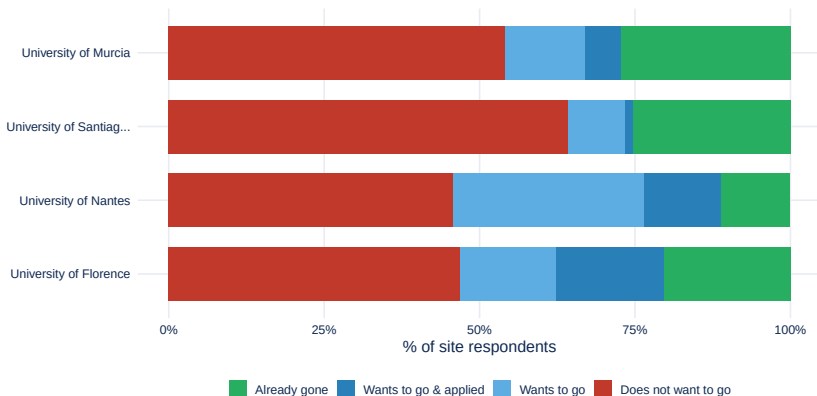
Variable	Test	Statistic	p-value	Sig.
genre	Chi-squared	17.79	0.041	Yes
niveau	Chi-squared	207.18	0.000	Yes
zone_geo	Chi-squared	43.26	0.012	Yes
parental_erasmus	Chi-squared	4.96	0.179	No
moyenne_acad_norm	Kruskal-Wallis	54.00	0.000	Yes
aisance_fin	Kruskal-Wallis	10.12	0.018	Yes
score_intl	Kruskal-Wallis	193.90	0.000	Yes
educ_num	Kruskal-Wallis	25.93	0.000	Yes

Reading: $p < 0.05$ = group difference is statistically reliable. n.s. = not significant with this sample size – not the same as no effect.

University Effect: Group Composition by Site

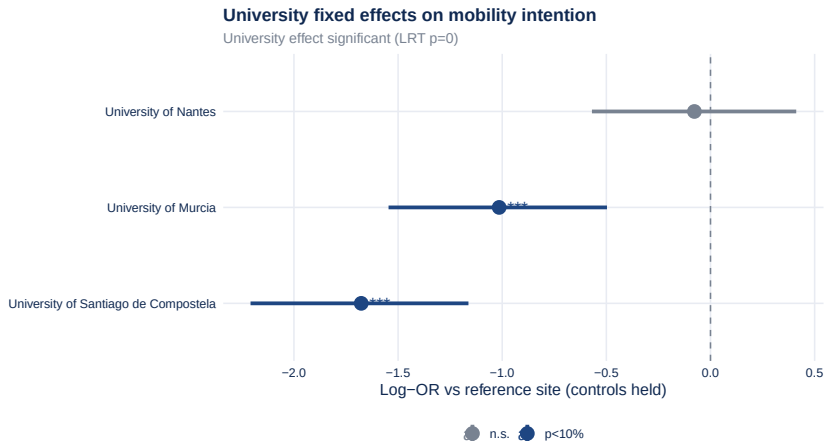
Group composition by university (n=4 sites)

Rows sum to 100% -- compare 'Wants to go' share across sites



Stacked bars show the share of each mobility group per site. Sites with a larger 'Already gone' share may have a stronger Erasmus culture or more systematic information. Compare the 'Does not want to go' share to identify sites with higher structural constraint.

University Effect: Fixed Effects Logit

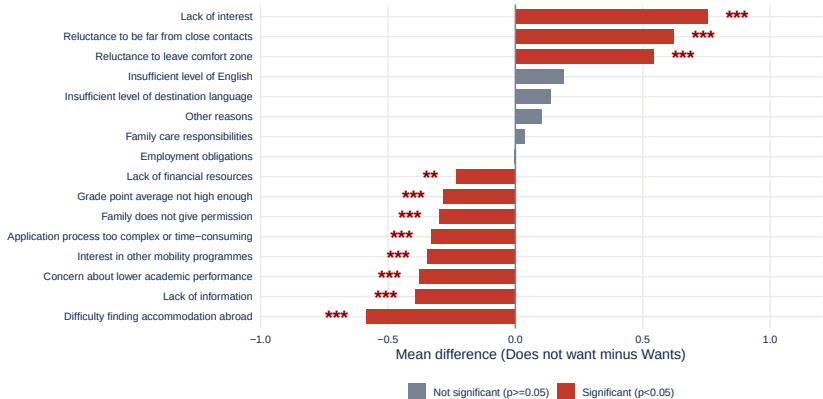


*University fixed effects after controlling for financial comfort, academic grade, parental education and international profile score. A significant LRT ($p < 0.05$) means the site matters independently of who studies there. Coefficients are log-OR relative to the reference university (lowest alphabetical). Stars: * $p < 10\%$, ** $p < 5\%$, *** $p < 1\%$.*

Which Barriers Differentiate Wants vs Does Not Want to Go?

Barriers: Does not want vs Wants to go [n=970]

Wants to go n=319 x Does not want n=651 | * p<0.10 ** p<0.05 *** p<0.01 (Mann-Whitney)

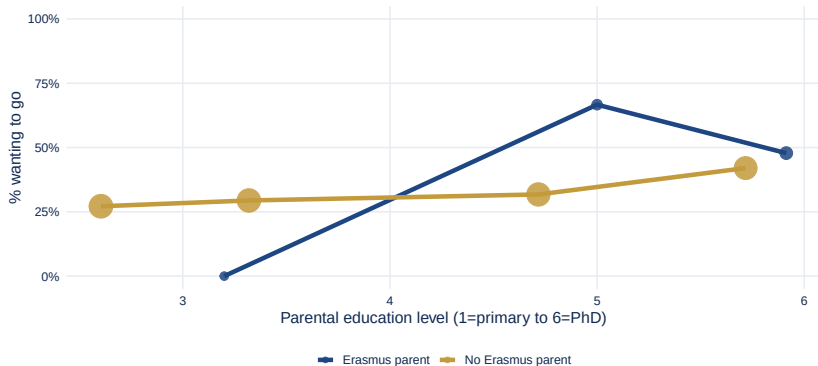


Positive bars = barriers rated higher by students who do NOT want to go. Red bars (starred) are statistically significant (Mann-Whitney $p < 0.05$): 11 out of 16 barriers. These are the barriers that genuinely differentiate the two groups.

Interaction: Parental Erasmus x Parental Education

Parental education x Parental Erasmus → Mobility intention

Interaction n.s. ($p=0.301$) -- Logit: $y \sim \text{educ}(z) * \text{parental_erasmus}$ -- $n=970$



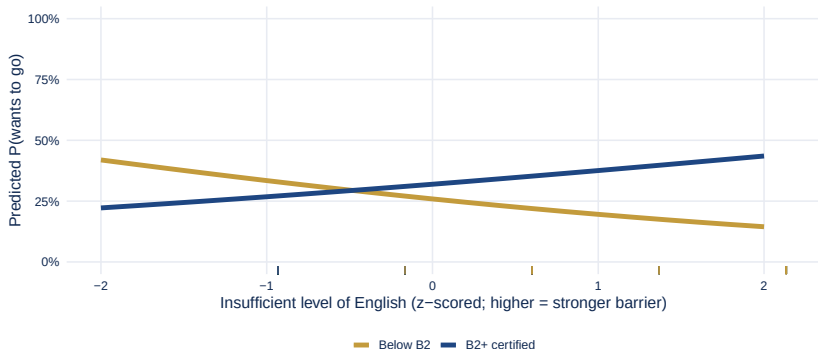
Lines show % of students wanting to go by parental education quartile, split by parental Erasmus experience. A significant interaction ($p < 0.05$) would mean the education gradient is steeper (or flatter) when a parent has done Erasmus – distinguishing general cultural capital from programme-specific knowledge. Point size = cell n.

Interaction: Certified English x Language Barrier

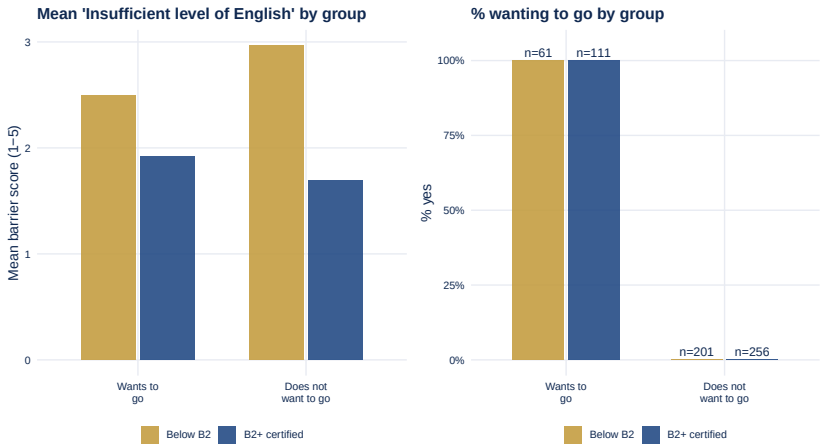
English level x Language barrier → Mobility intention

Interaction significant ($p=0.002$) | B2+ $n=367$, Below B2 $n=262$

Barrier: Insufficient level of English



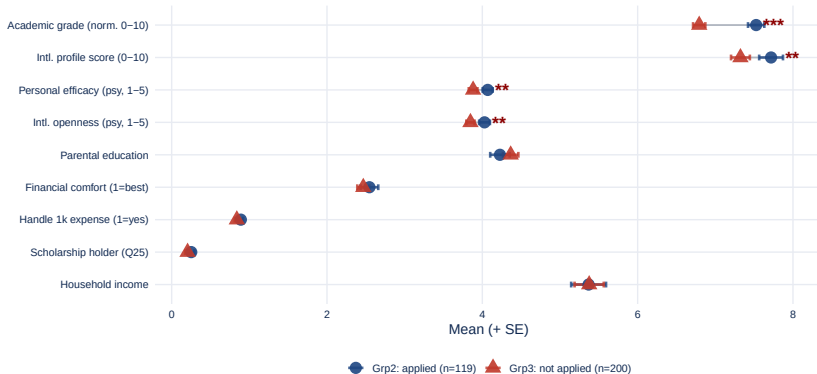
Predicted probability of wanting to go as a function of perceived language barrier, split by English certification status (B2+ vs below B2, Q24). A significant interaction confirms that certification attenuates the language barrier: certified students show a weaker negative slope between perceived language difficulty and mobility intention.



Left: mean perceived language barrier score (1=no obstacle, 5=major obstacle) by mobility group and certification level. Right: % wanting to go by group and certification level. If certified students perceive a lower barrier AND show higher mobility intention, the certification is doing double duty – both reducing perceived difficulty and boosting confidence.

Profile comparison: Group 2 vs Group 3 [n=319]

Grp2 n=119 vs Grp3 n=200 | * $p<0.10$ ** $p<0.05$ *** $p<0.01$ (Mann-Whitney)

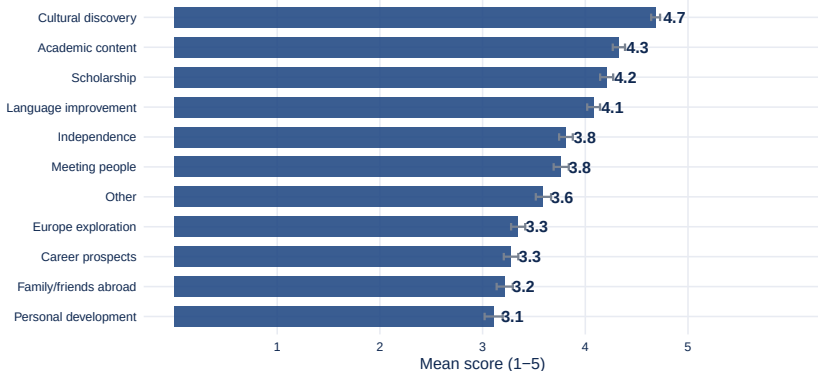


frein_ items excluded (NA for Grp2 by design). Blue circle = Grp2 (applied), red triangle = Grp3 (not applied). 4 variable(s) significantly different at $p<0.05$ (Mann-Whitney).

Reasons for Going – Group 1 (Already Gone)

Reasons for going -- Group 1: Already gone [n=260]

1 = not at all important | 5 = very important | bars = mean $\pm$ SE

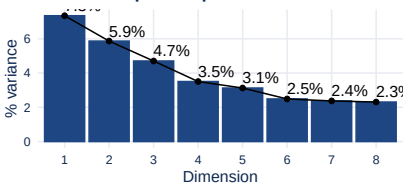


The 'reasons for going' question (raison_) is answered only by Group 1 (already gone). Other groups (2, 3, 4) did not answer this question. To compare motivations between Groups 2 and 3, refer to the barrier gap plots.

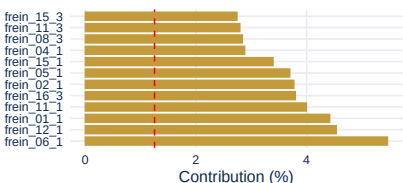


MCA on Barriers

Variance explained per dimension

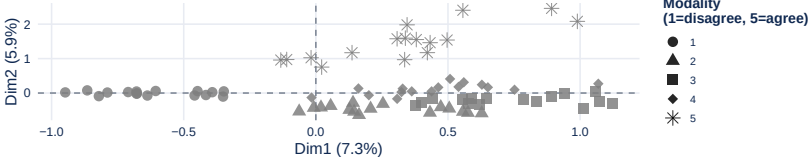


Contribution of barriers to Dim1



MCA -- modality map (Dim1 x Dim2)

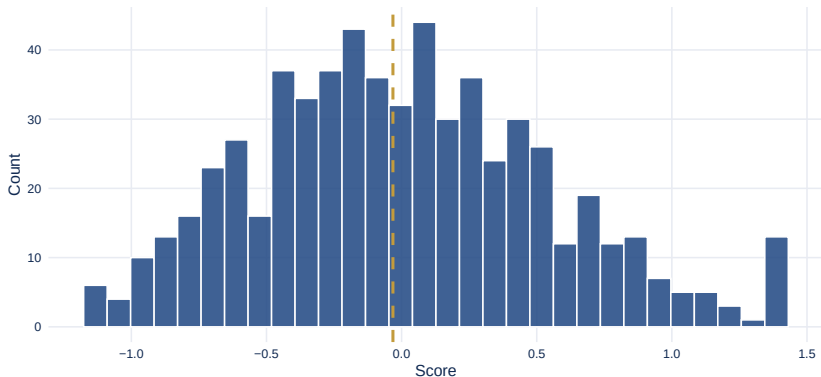
Dim1: 7.3% -- Dim2: 5.9% of variance



Composite Barrier Score

Composite Barrier Score -- Option B (MCA Dim1)

Dashed = median -- n = 613 | Composite barrier score (MCA Dim1, recentred)



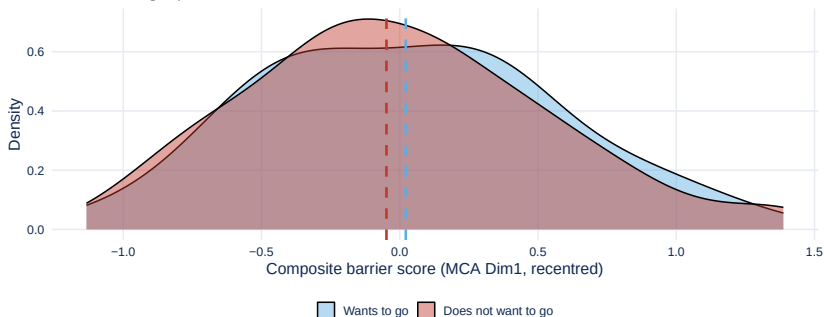
Scope limitation

The barrier items (`frein_`) were not administered to **Group 2** (applied, $n = 119$) due to questionnaire routing: **100%** of their scores are NA. All score-based analyses (distribution, OLS, KW) therefore cover **Groups 1, 3 and 4 only**. Group 2 appears in group-level plots as an empty or near-empty curve.

Composite Barrier Score – Distribution

Composite barrier score — Option B (MCA Dim1)

Dashed lines = group medians



Reading: dashed lines = group medians. Curves shifted right = more barriers felt. Group 2 (applied) is absent from this plot (100% NA on barrier items). Groups 1, 3 and 4 are the analytic base for all score-based comparisons.

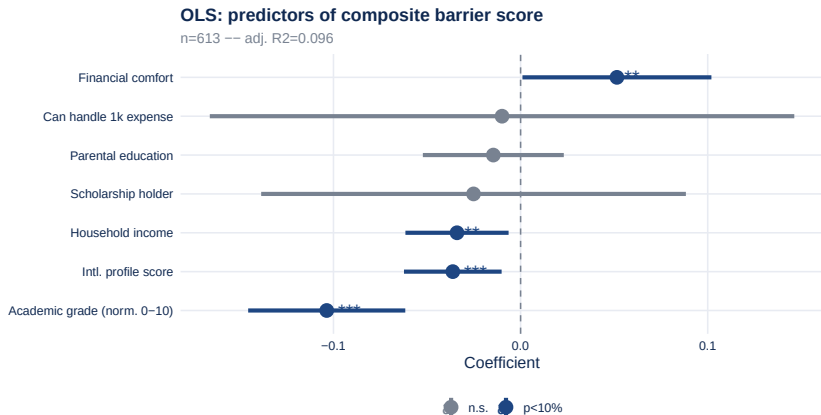
Score by Group: Does It Separate the Four Groups?



Kruskal-Wallis across 4 groups: $p=0.496$. Higher score = more barriers felt.

Caution: *Group 2 contributes only 0% non-missing scores — its box is near-empty and should not be interpreted.*

What Socio-Demo Variables Predict the Score?

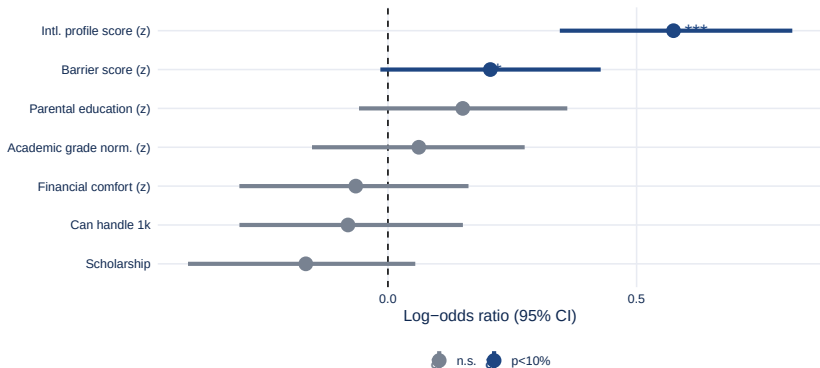


Reading: bars right = variable increases barrier score. Stars = significance ($p<10\%$, ** $p<5\%$). Financial comfort is coded 1 = very comfortable to 5 = not comfortable: its positive coefficient means students who are less financially comfortable perceive more barriers. Group 2 is excluded de facto (100% NA on the dependent variable).*

Logistic Regression: Movers vs Non-Movers

Logit: who wants to go? (Yes vs No)

Log-OR, standardized predictors (z) | n=607



Reading: % change in odds of wanting to go. International profile is typically the dominant predictor. Significant barriers with negative effect actively deter mobility intention.

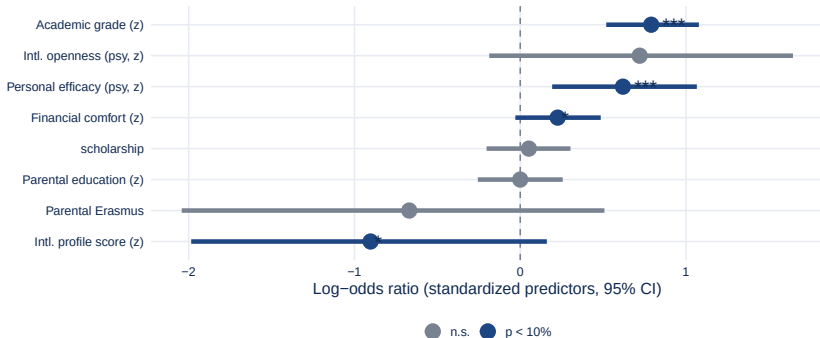
Applied vs Did Not Apply (Groups 2 vs 3)

What drives the decision to apply? (Logistic regression)

Groups 2 vs 3 | complete cases n=315 (applied: 118, not applied: 197)

Predictors standardized (z). Barrier score excluded (NA for Grp2).

Raw: Grp2=119, Grp3=200



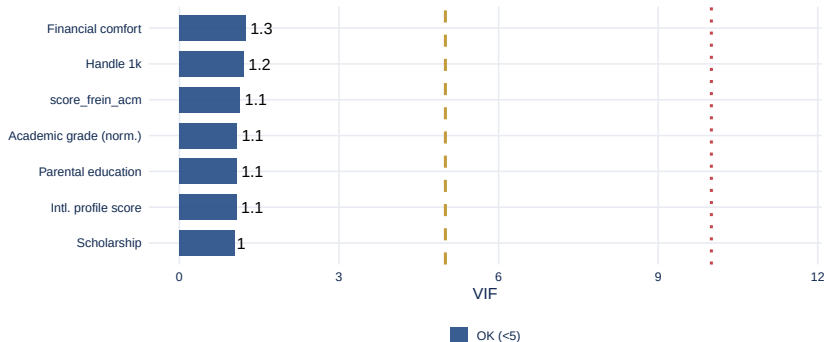
Reading: % change in odds of applying among students who want to go.

Barrier score: Method A (simple mean, robust to partial NA). Same desire, different action – what tips the balance towards applying?

Multicollinearity Check (VIF)

Variance Inflation Factors -- Movers logit

Dashed = VIF 5 (moderate) -- Dotted = VIF 10 (severe) -- Values < 5: no issue

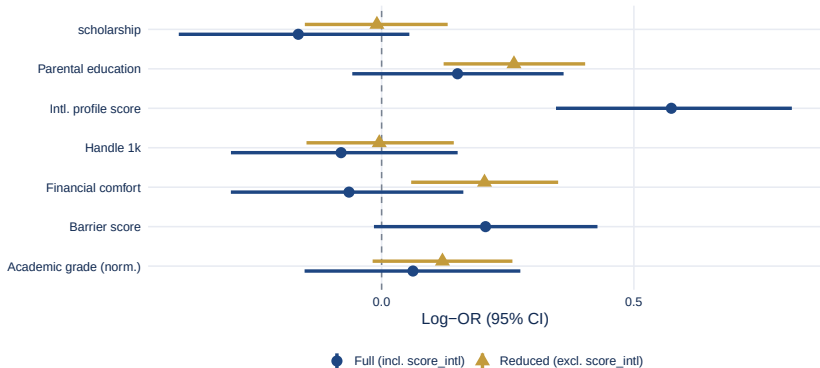


*VIF (Variance Inflation Factor) measures how much a predictor's variance is inflated by collinearity with others. $VIF > 5$ = moderate concern; $VIF > 10$ = severe. Here: 0 predictor(s) with $VIF \geq 5$, 0 with $VIF \geq 10$. Financial variables (*aisance_fin*, *revenu_num*, *depense_imp*) are the most likely collinear cluster; removing one or replacing all three with the structural vulnerability composite is recommended if $VIF > 5$.*

Robustness Check: Reduced Model

Robustness: full vs reduced movers logit

LRT not available -- Stable coefficients = no masking by collinearity

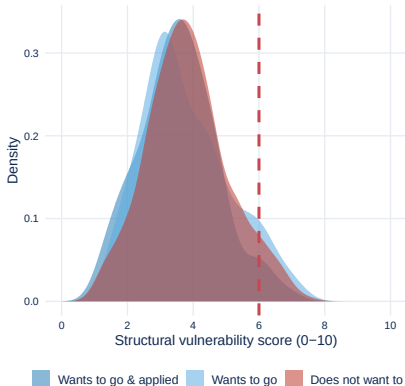


Blue = full model; gold = reduced model without `score_intl` (international profile score). If structural coefficients (financial comfort, parental education, grade) change substantially between models, `score_intl` was masking them. Structural coefficients (financial, parental, academic) are stable across specifications. If the LRT is n.s., `score_intl` may be dropped without loss of explanatory power for structural effects

Vulnerability Score: Validation

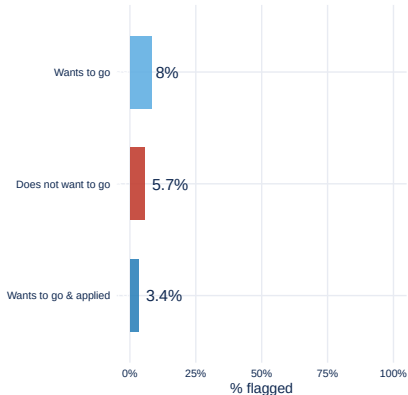
Vulnerability score distribution by group

Dashed = threshold $V > 6$ (resigned non-mover flag)



% with $V > 6$ by group

If score is valid, Grp4 should have highest share



Variable	$V > 6$	$V \leq 6$	n ($V > 6$)
Financial comfort (1=best)	3.58	2.31	57
Academic grade (norm. 0-10)	6.28	7.05	56
Parental education (1-6)	2.77	4.18	57
Intl. profile score (0-10)	7.04	6.85	57
Scholarship holder (%)	40.1%	21.2%	57

Methodological limits

- **Cross-sectional design:** associations only, no causal inference. Psychological profile may be shaped *by* the experience of applying, not only precede it.
- **Self-selection bias:** voluntary participation likely under-represents the most disengaged students (Grp4), biasing barrier scores downward.
- **Group 2 size:** if $n < 20$, logistic regression estimates are unstable — interpret with caution.
- **Barrier items unavailable for Grp2:** all score-based comparisons exclude applied students by design.

Measurement limits

- **Measurement invariance not tested:** psy items assumed to measure the same constructs equally across groups.
- **Likert interval assumption:** profile scores treat 1–2–3–4–5 as equally spaced; ordinal modelling not implemented.
- **Vulnerability weights (0.4/0.3/0.3):** theoretically motivated, not empirically derived; no sensitivity analysis.
- **Grade normalisation:** assumes students report grades on their university scale — no cross-check available.

Scope

Results valid for the surveyed sample

Replication across additional cohorts

3 Mechanisms Confirmed

- **Structural:** financial comfort, parental capital, grades predict barrier score and group membership
- **Psychological:** international profile score is the strongest predictor of mobility intention
- **Informational:** lack of knowledge about procedures is independently significant

Key Finding

Grp2 vs Grp3 (applied vs not): gap driven more by **psychological profile** and **information access** than by financial constraints.

3 Action Levers

- **Info.** Clear guides + Erasmus testimonials
- **Psych.** Intercultural events from Year 1
- **Struct.** Emergency grants for constrained profiles

Limitation

$n = 1230$ respondents. Group 2 may be small — interpret with caution. Data collection ongoing.

Group 3 → Group 2 (lever priority)

Students who want to go but haven't applied:

- Simplify the application process
- Peer mentoring from Group 1 (already gone)
- Early information sessions (Year 1)
- Address financial uncertainty with clear grant info

Group 4 (resigned non-movers)

Students who don't want to go due to constraint:

- Build international openness through local activities
- Short mobility formats (1–2 weeks)
- Targeted financial support for vulnerability score > 6

Do not conflate

Deliberate non-movers (free choice) vs resigned non-movers (constrained). Different approaches needed.



Thank you for your attention

Pascaline VINCENT

Questions, comments, further analyses?

Full specifications in appendix

Appendix



Models Estimated

1. **MCA** on barrier items (dimension reduction, 15 items)
2. **Composite score** (MCA Dim1 or simple mean)
3. **OLS** of score on socioeconomic + psychological variables
4. **Logit 1** — Yes/No mobility intention (all 4 groups)
5. **Logit 2** — Applied vs not applied (Groups 2 vs 3)

Logit specification

$$\text{logit Pr}(Y_i = 1) = \alpha + \sum_j \beta_j Z_{ij}$$

Reported as odds ratios (OR). OR — 1 = % change in odds. McFadden $R^2 > 0.20$ = good fit.

Caution

$n = 1230$: limited power. Group 2 may have $n < 30$. Listwise deletion for all models.

Standardisation formula

All continuous predictors in regressions are standardized:

$$Z_{ij} = \frac{X_{ij} - \bar{X}_j}{\sigma_j}$$

$\bar{X}_j$ and σ_j computed on the analytic sample.

Variables standardized (logistic models):

- Financial comfort `aisance_fin` (1–5)
- Academic grade `moyenne_acad_norm` (0–10, normalised)
- Parental education `educ_num` (1–6)
- Household income `revenu_num`

Why standardize?

- Avoids overflow in `glm()` when scales differ
- Makes coefficients comparable: 1 unit = 1 SD shift
- Does **not** affect significance or model fit

Binary / factor predictors

`depense_imp` (0/1) and `parental_erasmus` (factor) are **not** standardized. Coefficients = log-OR for the reference change (0→1 or No→Yes).

OLS barrier score model

Predictors **not** standardized in OLS. Coefficients — effect of 1-unit change on original scale.

Scores & composites

Intl. profile (0–10):

$$\text{score_intl} = \frac{\bar{x}_{8 \text{ items}} - 1}{4} \times 10$$

Items: travailler_etr, intl, cultures, tolerance, europe_id, curiosite, adaptation, monde

Intl. openness (1–5): row mean of travailler_etr, intl, cultures, tolerance, europe_id

Personal efficacy (1–5): row mean of resolution, equipe, adaptation, solutions

Grade normalisation:

$$\text{acad_norm} = \frac{\text{grade}}{\text{max}} \times 10$$

Florence /30 · Nantes /20 · others /10

Structural vulnerability (0–10)

$$V_i = (0.4 F_i + 0.3 A_i + 0.3 E_i) / 5 \times 10$$

- F_i : aisance_fin + revenu_num + depense_imp
- $A_i = (10 - \text{acad_norm}) / 10 \times 5$
- $E_i = (7 - \text{educ_num}) / 6 \times 5$

Missing → 2.5. Score 0=low, 10=high constraint.

Threshold $V_i > 6$ = resigned non-mover.

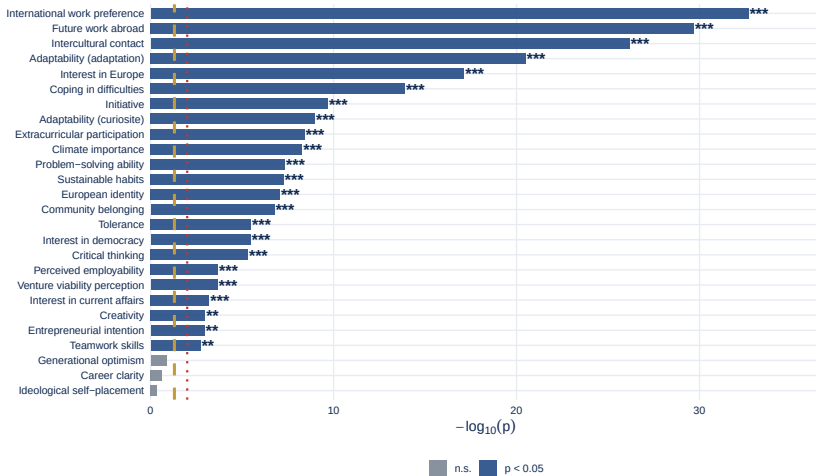
Z-score reminder

Logistic predictors standardized:

$$Z = (X - \bar{X}) / \sigma.$$

Binary vars (depense_imp, parental_erasmus) not standardized.
OLS uses raw scales.

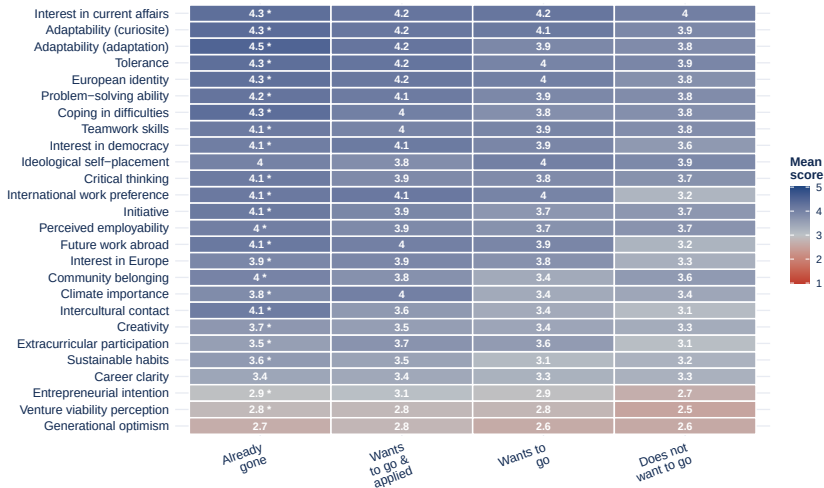
Kruskal-Wallis: each psy variable vs 4 groups

Dashed = $p=0.05$ --- dotted = $p=0.01$ -- psy_science excluded (binary)

23 out of 26 psy variables show significant group differences ($p < 0.05$, Kruskal-Wallis). Most discriminating: International work preference, Future work abroad, Intercultural contact. Stars: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, $p < 0.10$.

Mean score per psy variable × group (heatmap)

* in first column = significant Kruskal-Wallis ($p < 0.05$) - psy_science excluded



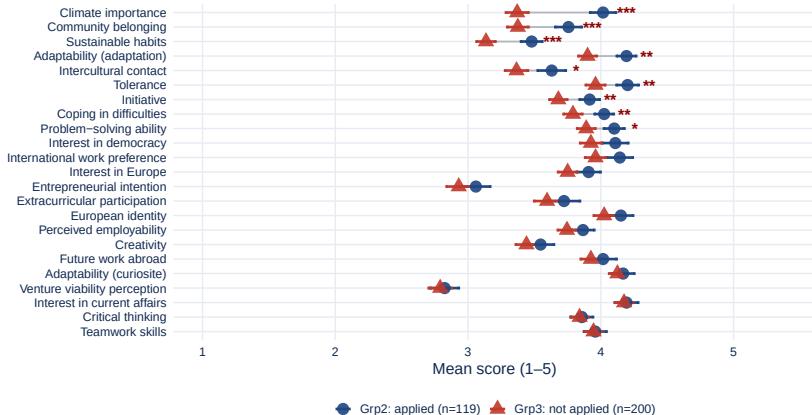
Heatmap: blue = high score (1–5), red = low score. Each cell shows the group mean. Variables marked * differ significantly across the 4 groups

(Kruskal-Wallis $p < 0.05$). Reading rows: variables with large colour contrast across groups are the most discriminating

Psy Variables: Groups 2 vs 3 (Significant Only)

Psy variables: Group 2 vs Group 3

Only variables significant in KW (4 groups) shown · n=319 · * p<0.10 ** p<0.05 *** p<0.01 (Mann-Wi)



Variables shown: 23 (significant in Kruskal-Wallis across 4 groups). Among these, 7 also differ significantly between Groups 2 and 3 (Mann-Whitney $p<0.05$). Blue circle = Grp2 (applied), red triangle = Grp3 (not applied). Sorted by absolute mean difference – most discriminating at top.